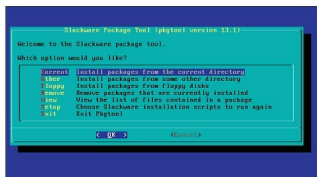




KDE 4.4.3 Default look



pkgtool – Slackware's package tracking system

distribution. Still, certain problems remain. Being a laptop user, I found the default audio levels to be quite low (when compared to Windows 7), even with all the volume bars in *alsamixer* set at the maximum level. This is an ALSA issue.

Slackware also means a *huge* download if you run 64-bit! If you are using the 32-bit version, you can choose to download just the first three CD ISOs, which will serve your installation needs. (The remaining 3 CDs/ISOs are source code.) However, if you run 64-bit, then you are forced to download the entire 4.1 GB of the DVD ISO; they don't split the x64 ISO into CD images, due to bandwidth and server space restrictions.

The collection of software is also quite odd. I mean, what's the point of forcing users to download a huge set of software? Do we really need three different browsers and two different e-mail clients? And two different kernels? A number of development tools are also provided which are irrelevant and useless for non-programmers. They should at least consider releasing a minimal version, something like Slackware Lite, for users who just want a usable desktop system! (Yes, it is possible to choose the expert option while installing, and select packages manually, or by using tag-files—but that is quite tedious and time-consuming.)

Slackware: Where does it stand today?

Although Slackware Linux is a mature enough distribution (17 years is a long time—we are talking about pre-Windows 95 days!), it has grown without much attention being paid to making it 'easier for the masses'. Of the countless Linux distributions launched in the past decade, probably the one distribution that rose to fame efficiently and quickly is Ubuntu Linux. Based on Debian, its philosophy and marketing standpoint was that it bridged the gap between Free Software users and 'ignorant' or unaware proprietary software users. It succeeded in this task. Though started just around six years ago, Ubuntu now has over 10 million users worldwide, according to Canonical, its UK-based sponsor. Slackware's goal and design was entirely the opposite. No, I'm not accusing Patrick Volkerding of making Slackware difficult for newbies, nor am I suggesting that he deliberately decided to restrict entry to the longest-surviving Linux operating system. Instead, I'm lauding him for staying true to his promise. Despite the competition, Slackware Linux still prides itself on having numerous faithful users across the globe. So why do these people prefer Slackware over an easier alternative like Ubuntu? Is it because all that glitters is not gold? Or is it because they are fond of the punishment? Let's find out.

While the number of Linux distributions is growing exponentially, the competition is becoming ridiculously challenging. It is becoming impossible to spot any real difference between distributions. Apparently, all you have to do is just re-brand an existing distribution along with new artwork, add to the duplication of effort, and set up your own website—and you have a brand new Linux distro!

The intimidating distributions like Debian, Arch Linux and Gentoo have their own successful forks to help newbies take a 'bite of the cake' (of these advanced Linux distributions) without facing too much hardship. But where exactly does Slackware stand among all these competitors? It is the oldest, but is it the hardest? Far from it! Slackware Linux is actually a very simple and easy-to-use system, provided you are an eager learner. Some working knowledge of Linux, or even a "Linux for Dummies" handbook would suffice. The only problem is that it is less 'bling' and more 'vanilla'. Let's take a brief tour of the Slackware system.

Do-it-yourself (DIY)

One of the fundamental tenets of Slackers (that's what Slackware users often call themselves) is to have the power to configure their own system from a vanilla install. Unlike Ubuntu or OpenSUSE, Slackware doesn't come bundled with a stack of shiny GUI configuration tools and utilities. Slackware is known to be the most true to upstream developers' preferences. Applying only the necessary security patches and bug-fixes, Slackware